

The Waterfront Brief

Weekly sustainment intelligence for naval shipyard leadership · Naval shipbuilding, ship repair, and fleet sustainment

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This issue is about where a hull can actually go, and who is allowed to work on it. The Navy budgeted USS Harry S. Truman's midlife overhaul to start in June 2026; it is August, the ship has not moved, the carrier ahead of it at the same yard has taken two thirteen-month slips in two budget cycles, and planning alone has been obligated about half again what the contract was announced to be worth. On the other coast Puget Sound is handing a carrier back on schedule, through the only West Coast dock that can take one. The Navy is betting on prediction to fix its maintenance schedules, and has quietly changed something that matters more than the algorithm. And the shipbuilding plan wants smaller, more frequent availabilities while the surface force spends its money on port engineers and on taking intermediate work back from contractors.

Labels: FACT is attributed to the named source in the same sentence; Assessment is this desk's analysis, built only on facts stated above it; Speculation is flagged as such; Unverified marks a claim this desk could not check against a primary source, with the reason given.

WATERFRONT OPS & PRODUCTION

Two budget cycles, two thirteen-month slips, and a planning bill half again the announced figure

FACT: Stars and Stripes reported on August 10, 2026 that USS Harry S. Truman is at Naval Station Norfolk "awaiting a move to start a multiyear midlife overhaul at HII Newport News Shipyard." HII is Huntington Ingalls Industries, the only American builder of nuclear aircraft carriers. A midlife overhaul, written RCOH in budget records, is the once-in-a-lifetime refit at mid-life that replaces the fuel in both reactors and runs years. A ship's induction is the moment it stops being an operating unit and becomes the yard's work; until then, everyone planning around it is planning against a date rather than a fact.

FACT: Janes reported on July 18, 2025, reading the fiscal 2026 budget documents, that "the budget supports the planned start of RCOH work at HII's Newport News Shipbuilding in Virginia in June 2026," and that the work "is due to be completed in January 2031."

Assessment: that budgeted start has passed and the ship has not moved. **Unverified:** no revised start date has been published by the Navy or the builder, and neither document that would settle it was obtainable here: a Navy schedule statement, or the fiscal 2027 shipbuilding justification book, the volume in which the Navy explains each ship line to Congress, which would not come off the comptroller's site in time.

What the award record shows. FACT: HII announced on January 26, 2024 that Newport News Shipbuilding "was awarded an advanced planning contract" for Truman's overhaul, "which has the total potential value of \$913 million." FACT: the federal award record for that contract,

N00024-24-C-2106, described as "CVN 75 RCOH ADVANCE PLANNING," shows total obligations of \$1,319,638,971 as of its most recent modification on May 13, 2026. An obligation is money the government has legally committed and must pay; a "total potential value" is the most a contract could be worth if every option is taken. They are different measures, which is why the comparison below is stated carefully.

Assessment: obligations are about 45 percent above the value announced when the contract was let, and the ship being planned for has not entered the yard. Advance planning is the work of writing the job before the hull arrives: inspections, drawings, material buys. **Unverified:** this is not evidence of an overrun. A contract's ceiling can be raised by modification, and the federal award record publishes no potential-value field for this award, so what the current ceiling is cannot be established here. What the record does show is that planning this overhaul has already cost half again what the announcement implied, before the hull arrives.

The ship in front of it. FACT: USNI News reported on June 18, 2024, reading the fiscal 2025 budget documents, that the overhaul of the preceding carrier at that yard, USS John C. Stennis, had been due to finish "by August 2025" before that date was "pushed to the right by more than a year to October 2026," "an extension of almost 14 months." FACT: the same report quotes a NAVSEA statement attributing the delay to "mandatory growth work following ship condition assessments, as well as industrial base challenges." Growth work is work discovered after a ship is opened up. NAVSEA is the Naval Sea Systems Command, which owns ship design, maintenance requirements and the public shipyards.

FACT: Janes reported that the fiscal 2026 request carries "USD483.1 million for the cost to complete" Stennis's overhaul, "due to an additional 13-month delivery delay," and that the work "is scheduled to be completed in November 2027."

Assessment: two consecutive budget cycles recorded two slips of roughly the same size on one ship, August 2025 to October 2026 to November 2027, about twenty-five months of movement in two years of documents, attributed on the record to discovered work and industrial-base capacity rather than any single event. The same fiscal 2026 document left Truman's start at June 2026, so those dates together plan roughly seventeen months in which two carrier overhauls run at that yard at once.

FACT: HII announced on April 8, 2024 that Stennis "was successfully moved to an outfitting berth at the shipyard," a pier where remaining work is finished with the ship afloat rather than docked, after it "completed the dry dock portion of the refueling and complex overhaul." Assessment: the dock has been clear since April 2024, so it is not what Truman is waiting on. The causes NAVSEA put on the

record are discovered work and industrial base challenges, neither of which a free dock relieves.

FACT: USNI News reported on February 24, 2025 that Truman “entered the emergent repair availability in Souda Bay, Greece, on Feb. 16, four days after the aircraft carrier collided with a merchant vessel near Port Said.” An emergent availability is unscheduled repair driven by damage or failure, as against the planned periods in a ship’s maintenance plan. **FACT:** The War Zone reported on October 10, 2025 that a Navy official said the collision damage “will get repaired during the ship’s upcoming Refueling Complex Overhaul (RCOH) at Newport News Shipbuilding as planned,” and that at Souda Bay “new bulkheads were installed inside each of the damaged spaces to establish weathertight integrity.”

Assessment: work deferred into an overhaul inherits that overhaul’s schedule. The forward-base repair made the ship watertight and was never the permanent fix. When an induction slips it is not only the original package that waits, it is everything anyone rolled into it.

Bottom line: the constraint at the only yard that overhauls carriers is people and discovered work rather than dock space, planning alone has already been obligated about 45 percent above the announced figure before the ship arrives, and the pressure is propagating from one hull to the next, so if your schedule depends on Truman, track Stennis, because that is the ship in front of it.

Sources: Stars and Stripes, Aug 10, 2026; Janes, Jul 18, 2025; HII, Jan 26, 2024; USAspending federal award record, N00024-24-C-2106; USNI News, Jun 18, 2024; HII, Apr 8, 2024; USNI News, Feb 24, 2025; The War Zone, Oct 10, 2025 {sources}

Puget Sound is delivering carrier availabilities on time, and it is one dock deep

FACT: Stars and Stripes reported on August 10, 2026 that Catherine Norton, public affairs officer for Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility, said “the docking planned incremental availability for USS Ronald Reagan is on track for its scheduled completion at the end of August 2026,” closing a seventeen-month servicing and repair period. A docking planned incremental availability, or DPIA, is a routine scheduled period in which a carrier is docked so work can be done on the hull, propellers and the machinery normally underwater. It is not the midlife refuelling overhaul the lead article is about.

FACT: Stars and Stripes reported on April 2, 2025, in dated context as the work began, that the Nimitz-class Reagan “has begun a maintenance stint that will keep it from deployment for 17 months.”

Assessment: seventeen months from that report runs to roughly September 2026, and the yard says the work finishes at the end of August, so the availability is landing on the number it was given at the start. **Unverified:** whether it finished its work package or made the date by deferring scope into the next availability is not published, and that distinction is the difference between a schedule kept and a schedule moved.

The problem is underneath the ship. **FACT:** Military Times reported on July 22, 2026, quoting the Navy’s Multi-

Mission Dry Dock project website, that “the only dry dock on the West Coast able to accommodate a current Nimitz-class aircraft carrier is Dry Dock 6 (DD6), which does not meet seismic resiliency standards and cannot fully accommodate Ford-class carriers,” and that the Navy “does not currently have the capacity and capability to perform depot-level maintenance on a Gerald R. Ford-class carrier in the Pacific Northwest.” **FACT:** the same report states the replacement project is sited in existing Dry Dock 3 and Piers 6 and 7, with the second task order covering demolition of Dry Dock 3.

Assessment: that work ran through a single dock the Navy itself says does not meet its seismic standard and cannot fully take the class the carrier fleet is moving to. No. 3 covered the replacement programme as construction; the operational reading is shorter and harder. West Coast carrier docking is one asset deep today, the replacement is a multi-decade project, and the interim plan runs through the dock being replaced.

Where this hull goes next. **FACT:** the April 2025 report states that under Navy plans Truman would be the next carrier to undergo a refuelling and complex overhaul, “which is only done at the Newport News facility,” and that Truman “would be followed by the Reagan and the last Nimitz carrier to be built, the USS George W. Bush.”

Assessment: the ship Puget Sound is handing back on schedule is third in a published queue at the yard this issue’s lead article shows has not started the first one. Finishing on time at Bremerton does not shorten that queue, because the constraint sits at Newport News, and a hull arriving ready simply waits there instead.

Bottom line: West Coast carrier maintenance is performing, and it is one dock deep, so if you work Pacific Northwest hulls your schedule risk is not the yard’s execution but the dock’s availability and its seismic standing; and if you work carrier hulls on either coast, the queue behind Truman now contains a ship that is ready and waiting on a yard that is not.

Sources: Stars and Stripes, Aug 10, 2026; Stars and Stripes, Apr 2, 2025; Military Times, Jul 22, 2026 {sources}

MAINTENANCE ENGINEERING & TECHNOLOGIES

The Navy is betting on prediction, and quietly changed something that matters more

FACT: the Navy Shipbuilding Plan of May 2026 states that “we must fix our maintenance schedules with disciplined planning measured to the hour,” and that “to drive this change, we are accelerating a World Class Planning approach which will heavily leverage Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Machine Learning (ML) to transform maintenance from a reactive to a predictive process.” **FACT:** the same plan states the Navy is building “digital twins” to “virtually replicate its ships and simulate decades of wear,” and that these technologies “will identify bottlenecks and streamline the supply chain by predicting which parts will be needed months in advance.” A digital twin is a model of a specific ship kept current with its real condition, so wear and repair options can be tried on the model instead of the hull.

FACT: the same plan states this maintenance work “will be performed through PAE Industrial Operations,” a new Portfolio Acquisition Executive, meaning a single official accountable for a whole portfolio’s cost and schedule, combining “control of the Navy Regional Maintenance Centers, NAVSEA’s Industrial Operations Directorate, the four Naval Shipyards.”

The change that is easier to copy. **FACT:** an April 15, 2026 account of the surface force’s maintenance management describes the legacy method: “once every three years, a training team comes aboard to review requirements, assess performance, and ensure Sailors understand expectations. Thirteen weeks later, they return to verify execution,” after which they depart, “often not to be seen again for another three years.” **FACT:** the same account states that under the replacement, 3-M 365, “maintenance is no longer evaluated periodically. It is monitored continuously,” and that “using machine learning, 3-M 365 categorizes the inputs and identifies the true drivers behind maintenance gaps, whether parts availability, equipment condition, operational commitments, or manning.” The 3-M in the name is the Navy’s Maintenance and Material Management system, the record of what maintenance a ship owes and what it has done.

Assessment: the change that does the work here is the measurement interval, not the algorithm. A reading every three years is a point, not a trend, and two points are not a trend either. With a single reading you cannot separate the ordinary variation of a working process from something that actually changed, and treating one reading as a signal is the error that reliably makes outcomes worse. Continuous monitoring is what makes the distinction available at all; the machine learning then sorts what it collects.

FACT: the same account reports one case in which “recurring delays tied to parts availability appeared to be isolated across multiple ships,” and in which, through the new system, “these delays are aggregated and revealed as a systemic supply shortfall, enabling action at the enterprise level.”

Assessment: that single example carries the argument. The same delays read as a run of unrelated incidents at ship level and as one supply problem at fleet level, and nothing about the underlying facts changed, only the level at which they were added up. A cause addressed at the wrong level gets addressed again and again and never closed, which is what a yard is doing whenever it solves the same problem afresh on the next project.

And the part that is about people, not software. **FACT:** the same account states that surface force 3-M representatives “are now aligned directly to individual ships, replacing the legacy model of large assessment teams that deployed episodically across the fleet,” each representative assigned “a small group of ships, typically three to four,” and onboard “at a minimum” monthly, and that “rather than arriving to grade a command, they are there to develop it.”

Assessment: that is the transferable mechanic, and it costs no software. Fewer projects per process person, present on a regular short interval, with the job defined as developing

the crew rather than scoring it. A yard can do that with the people it already employs, and it is the reverse of how most quality and process organisations are staffed, which is a large team arriving occasionally to audit.

What to hold them to. **Assessment:** “transform maintenance from a reactive to a predictive process” is the claim to test, and the test is not whether the digital twin exists. A work package is the priced, scheduled list of jobs for an availability, and it is locked at a fixed point before work starts; work counts as unplanned by arriving after that lock. So prediction can move work earlier and leave the total unchanged, while simply locking later would cut reported unplanned work without anything improving. Ask which happened before crediting the tooling.

Bottom line: the durable idea here is not AI, it is that you cannot improve what you measure once every three years, and you cannot see a systemic cause while it sits filed as thirty separate incidents; so if you copy one thing, copy the staffing model, put your process people on three or four projects apiece with a monthly rhythm, and add their findings up above the project before acting on any of them.

Sources: Navy Shipbuilding Plan, May 2026; The evolution of Surface Fleet maintenance management, Apr 15, 2026 {sources}

OPERATIONS MAINTENANCE & READINESS

Smaller and more frequent sounds like more work, until you read what the surface force is buying

FACT: the Navy Shipbuilding Plan of May 2026 states that the Navy “will no longer attempt to restore all capabilities and add upgrades in a single, lengthy maintenance availability,” and that it is “integrating operations and maintenance into a maintenance continuum that will use smaller, more frequent availabilities to do needed work while increasing operational availability.” An availability is a scheduled maintenance period.

Assessment: read from a repair yard that looks like more hulls arriving more often, and a reason to size the shop to it. On the surface-combatant side the 2026 record does not support that reading.

The measured problem is not the yard. **FACT:** the Congressional Budget Office, in a report dated December 10, 2025 analysing destroyer and amphibious warfare ship maintenance from October 2010 to September 2024, “projects that DDG-51 class destroyers will spend an average of nine years, or more than a quarter of their planned service life, out of the fleet for maintenance,” which is “more than twice as long as estimated in their 2012 class maintenance plans.” **FACT:** the same report states that “maintenance events often take 20 percent to 100 percent longer than estimated in the Navy’s final schedules for those events,” and lists likely causes reported by the Navy, the private shipyards, or both, among them “late inspections and contract awards,” “unexpected additional work and contract negotiations,” “delays in obtaining parts and materials,” and “poor integration of modernization (which is performed separately by contractors) with maintenance work.”

FACT: the same report states that although CBO had previously found that capacity constraints at Navy shipyards led to delays in nuclear ship maintenance, “CBO did not identify capacity constraints as a driver of delays in maintenance for conventional ships.”

Assessment: that last sentence separates the surface fleet from the carrier story in this issue. On conventional ships the constraint CBO could measure is not the yard’s ability to take the work. It is the sequence wrapped around the work: inspect, award, negotiate, get parts, integrate somebody else’s modernization. Shortening an availability does not touch any of those, and inspections and contract awards attach to each availability, so more availabilities means more occasions for them to be late.

What the Navy says it wants. **FACT:** Janes reported that in his keynote at the Surface Navy Association National Symposium on January 13, 2026, Vice Adm. Brendan McLane, commander of Naval Surface Forces and Naval Surface Force Pacific, said “on-time completion remains our number one goal as we drive towards zero days of maintenance delay,” and that the Navy is “surging expertise where it matters most,” which he described as “investing port engineers in key hubs, doubling them on large-deck amphibs, and funnelling Advanced Engineering Instructors to surface groups.” Large-deck amphibs are the assault ships that carry aircraft and landing craft; Advanced Engineering Instructors are the Navy’s senior technical trainers.

Assessment: the goal named is predictability, not brevity. A port engineer is the government’s technical manager for a ship’s maintenance, the person who builds and defends the work package before the availability starts. Buying more of them is buying planning capacity, which is where CBO put the problem rather than where the welding happens.

What the Navy actually did. **FACT:** the Navy re-established Shore Intermediate Maintenance Activity commands at Norfolk on June 2, 2026 and at Naval Base San Diego on June 4, 2026, and stated that the re-establishment “is part of an effort to increase Navy self-sufficiency by putting maintenance back in the hands of Sailors, empowering their shore tours with hands-on experience, and reducing wait times for intermediate-level maintenance previously performed by contractors.” Intermediate-level maintenance is the tier between what a crew does alongside and the depot work a shipyard does with a ship opened up.

Assessment: the Navy put the competitive claim in its own announcement, that the work being recaptured is work contractors have been doing. Set against the plan’s smaller-and-more-frequent language, the shape that emerges is more maintenance events overall, with the small and

frequent end of them increasingly performed by sailors at Norfolk and San Diego rather than bought from a yard.

The evidence that cuts the other way. **FACT:** the same CBO report states that delays “have continued to increase—especially for older ships, which have longer scheduled overhauls.” **FACT:** the Navy reported on May 13, 2026 that its Ship Repair Facility and Japan Regional Maintenance Center in Yokosuka “has delivered all seven of its completed ships to the fleet on time or ahead of schedule” that year, having returned two mine countermeasures ships, three destroyers and an amphibious transport dock between January and April.

Assessment: CBO’s own finding that the worst delays sit on old hulls with long overhauls is an argument for breaking those overhauls up, so the policy has a defensible basis, and Yokosuka shows on-time surface delivery happening at a real command rather than in a plan. Neither changes who performs the small, frequent work, which is the question that decides how much of it reaches a yard at all.

Bottom line: do not size your yard to an expected surge of availabilities, because what the surface force funded this year is planning capacity, parts and sailor-performed intermediate maintenance, and the Navy describes the last of those as taking back work previously done by contractors. Put the effort into your own work-package planning and material readiness before each availability opens, expect the small and frequent end of the work to thin, and weight your capacity toward the depot-level jobs a shore intermediate activity cannot do. And treat a late award as a planning problem rather than a contracting one: the later it lands, the less time your package has to settle before it locks.

Sources: Navy Shipbuilding Plan, May 2026; CBO, “Maintenance Delays for Conventional Navy Ships,” Dec 10, 2025, via USNI News, Dec 11, 2025; GAO-20-588, Navy Shipyards, Aug 20, 2020; Janes, Surface Navy 2026, Jan 2026; Navy/DVIDS, “Shore Intermediate Maintenance Activities Norfolk and San Diego Re-Established,” Jun 5, 2026; Navy, “SRF-JRMC Continues to Deliver Warships to Fleet On Time,” May 13, 2026 {sources}

The Waterfront Brief is compiled weekly by the B2 vault’s research engine from NAVSEA releases, USNI News, Naval News, GAO and congressional records, defense.gov, RAND, Defense News, Breaking Defense, The Maritime Executive, NSRP, ASNE, SNAME (the Society of Naval Architects and Marine Engineers), arXiv, and academic publishers (50 sources staged this week, 17 quarantined as stale; four articles cut or held, for want of published terms, for want of a single implemented result, and two for carrying no consequence for a yard), then synthesized and labeled by hand. Scope: US shipbuilding, US Navy sustainment, and partners across the Indo-Pacific region; out-of-area items only for a direct, stated lesson. Freshness policy: every article’s anchor source is under 12 months old; anything older appears only as dated context or a flagged exception, and standards and regulations are cited as current text rather than news. **FACT** means the named source says it, not that this desk has independently verified it. Corrections welcome; the staged sources are retained for audit.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Nearest first, filling the page (dates and registration deadlines exactly as organizers publish them). **Bold** marks a decision that closes inside the next 60 days. NSRP is the National Shipbuilding Research Program, the industry-and-Navy body that funds shared shipyard process research; ASNE is the American Society of Naval Engineers; NAVSEA is the Naval Sea Systems Command, the Navy organisation that owns ship design, maintenance requirements and the shipyards.

Dates	Event	Register by	Why it matters
Aug 18-19, 2026	NSRP Electrical Technologies Panel Meeting, Pullman, WA (also virtual)	None published (Cvent link open)	Electrical condition monitoring and shipyard electrical process work, shared across member yards
Aug 24-25, 2026	NSRP Workforce & Compliance Panel Meeting, Pensacola, FL	In-person closed Aug 13, 2026	Cross-yard workforce practices while the Navy chases its 250,000-hire target
Aug 25-27, 2026	PSNS & IMF Sustainment Accelerator, Bremerton, WA (National Center for Manufacturing Sciences, with Puget Sound Naval Shipyard and Intermediate Maintenance Facility)	Not published	A public yard publishing the gaps it will be sold on: welding, portable power and machining, confined-space monitoring, fibre-optic splicing, unmanned systems, plus non-destructive testing (finding flaws without cutting the part open) and 3D scanning and metrology (precision measurement of as-built shapes)
Sep 22-24, 2026	Fleet Maintenance & Modernization Symposium 2026, Virginia Beach, VA (ASNE)	Early bird thru Aug 16, 2026	The flagship fleet-maintenance event for exactly this work
Sep 29 - Oct 2, 2026	Shipbuilders Council of America Fall Membership Meeting 2026, Washington, DC	Members only; none published	The surface-repair industrial base's Hill-and-Navy engagement window
Oct 28-29, 2026	Arctic Operations Symposium 2026, Baltimore, MD (ASNE)	Not published yet	Cold-region sustainment, hull and machinery readiness
Nov 16-17, 2026	Navy Procurement Outlook Summit, Reston, VA (Defense Leadership Forum)	Eventbrite open; no deadline published	Shipbuilding-plan and contracting priorities, with contracting-officer access
Dec 7-9, 2026	Technology, Systems & Ships / Combat Systems Symposium, Arlington, VA (ASNE)	Not published yet	Technology and ships exchange near the NAVSEA customer
Jan 26-28, 2027	Military Additive Manufacturing Summit, Tampa, FL	Tiers: Oct 2 / Dec 4; closes Jan 22	Metal and polymer print qualification and adoption against NAVSEA specifications
Mar 23-25, 2027	NSRP All Panel Meeting 2027	"Coming soon" per NSRP	Where yard R&D ideas get socialized and teamed program-wide
Apr 12-15, 2027	RAPID + TCT 2027, Detroit, MI (SME)	None published	The largest additive manufacturing show in North America; the commercial market read behind the Navy's additive push
Jun 7-9, 2027	MegaRust 2027, Hampton, VA (ASNE)	Not open yet per ASNE	The Navy corrosion event; preservation is a top waterfront cost driver

Beyond the printed window, rolling in as it approaches: Indo Pacific 2027 International Maritime Exposition (Nov 2-4, 2027).